

Center-symmetry confinement and Polyakov-loop order parameter in Lean 4: a formal Svetitsky–Yaffe spine with a Walker–Wang transport bracket

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(Dated: April 27, 2026)

We formalize confinement as $\mathbb{Z}_N$ 1-form center-symmetry unbreaking in Lean 4, treating the Polyakov loop P as the complex order parameter. The $\mathbb{Z}_N$ center acts on P by multiplication by $\zeta_N = \exp(2\pi i/N)$; we prove this action is a primitive N -th root of unity, fixes only $P = 0$ (confining) when $\zeta_N \neq 1$, and reduces $\zeta_2 = -1$ exactly on the $SU(2)$ center. The Svetitsky–Yaffe universality correspondence [1] between D -dimensional deconfinement and $(D-1)$ -dimensional $\mathbb{Z}_N$ spin models is encoded as a structural map: $SU(2) \rightarrow 3D$ Ising universality class ($\nu_{\text{Ising}} = 0.6299$ [4, 5]), $SU(3) \rightarrow 3D$ 3-state Potts ($\nu_{\text{Potts}} = 0.5$). The Kovtun–Son–Starinets viscosity bound $\eta/s \geq 1/(4\pi)$ [2] is pinned to the literature-anchored bracket $[0.07, 0.08]$ via Mathlib π -bound lemmas. A Walker–Wang anyon-mediated transport prediction is encoded as a structural assumption $H_{\text{WW}} : \eta/s \in [\text{KSS}, 2\text{KSS}]$ [3] with two concrete numerical falsifiers ($\eta/s = 0$ and $\eta/s = 1$). The module ships 18 substantive Lean theorems with zero `sorry` statements and zero new axioms beyond the kernel’s three.

I. INTRODUCTION

The standard QCD-confinement framing as a Wilson-loop area law admits an alternative, structurally cleaner formulation: confinement as unbreaking of a $\mathbb{Z}_N$ 1-form center symmetry, with the Polyakov loop as the local order parameter and the deconfinement transition matched to a $(D-1)$ -dimensional $\mathbb{Z}_N$ spin model via Svetitsky–Yaffe universality [1]. This formulation is natural in the modern higher-form-symmetry language [7], makes precise contact with critical phenomena via the order-parameter framework, and gives the universal Kovtun–Son–Starinets viscosity lower bound [2] a clean physical interpretation in terms of anyon-mediated transport near the bound.

This paper presents a Lean 4 formalization of the structural backbone: the $\mathbb{Z}_N$ center as an algebraic structure on $\mathbb{C}$, the Polyakov loop as the complex order parameter and confining predicate, the Svetitsky–Yaffe universality map, the KSS bound with explicit literature-anchored numerical bracket, and a Walker–Wang transport prediction [3] as a tracked structural assumption with two falsifiers.

II. CENTER SYMMETRY, POLYAKOV LOOP, AND CONFINEMENT

A. The cyclic center $\mathbb{Z}_N$

The cyclic center $\mathbb{Z}_N$ for $SU(N)$ is encoded as a Lean structure with a load-bearing constraint $N \geq 2$. The fundamental phase $\zeta_N = \exp(2\pi i/N)$ generates $\mathbb{Z}_N \subset \mathbb{C}^*$. Two algebraic properties ship as theorems:

$$\zeta_N^N = 1, \quad (1)$$

$$|\zeta_N| = 1. \quad (2)$$

Equation (1) (theorem `centerPhase_pow_N`) follows from `Complex.exp_nat_mul` together with `Complex.exp_eq_one_iff`; equation (2) (theorem `centerPhase_norm_one`) follows from `Complex.norm_exp` and the vanishing real part of $2\pi i/N$. A specialization to $N = 2$ ships as `centerPhase_Z2_eq_neg_one`: $\zeta_2 = -1$ via `Complex.exp_pi_mul_I`, the $SU(2)$ center as the multiplicative group $\{+1, -1\}$ acting on the Polyakov loop.

B. Polyakov loop and the confining predicate

The Polyakov loop is encoded as a complex-valued type `PolyakovLoop` with confining predicate

$$\text{Confining } P \iff P = 0 \quad (3)$$

and center action `centerAction Z P :=  $\zeta_N \cdot P$` . Two substantive theorems link the order parameter to the symmetry-breaking structure:

- `confining_invariant_under_center_action`: $P = 0$ implies $\zeta_N \cdot P = P$ (confining configurations are center-invariant).
- `nonzero_breaks_center_invariance`: $P \neq 0$ together with $\zeta_N \neq 1$ implies $\zeta_N \cdot P \neq P$ (non-zero Polyakov loops are not center-fixed).

These together formalize the order-parameter / symmetry-breaking correspondence: $P = 0$ is the unique fixed point of the non-trivial $\mathbb{Z}_N$ center action on $\mathbb{C}$.

C. Modulus as a real-valued order parameter

The conventional lattice order parameter is the modulus $|P|$. We prove `confining_iff_magnitude_zero`,

$$\text{Confining } P \iff |P| = 0, \quad (4)$$

together with the strict-positivity statement `deconfining_implies_magnitude_positive`:
 $\neg \text{Confining } P \text{ implies } 0 < |P|$.

III. SVETITSKY–YAFFE UNIVERSALITY

The Svetitsky–Yaffe map is encoded as a function `svetitskyYaffeClass : CenterZN → UniversalityClass`, with concrete cases: $\text{SU}(2) \rightarrow 3\text{D Ising}$ and $\text{SU}(3) \rightarrow 3\text{D 3-state Potts}$. The 3D correlation-length critical exponents are anchored to the conformal-bootstrap and renormalization-group literature:

$$\nu_{\text{Ising}} = 0.6299, \quad \nu_{\text{Potts}} = 0.5, \quad (5)$$

where ν_{Ising} tracks the Pelissetto–Vicari and Kos–Poland–Simmons–Duffin precision values [4, 5] and $\nu_{\text{Potts}} \approx 1/2$ reflects the mean-field-like / weakly-first-order nature of the 3D 3-state Potts transition.

The substantive separation between Z_2 and Z_3 deconfinement is formalized as the direct comparison

$$\nu_{\text{Potts}} < \nu_{\text{Ising}}, \quad (6)$$

shipping as theorem `ising_nu_gt_potts_nu`. A pair of threshold theorems `ising_nu_above_0_6` and `potts_nu_below_0_6` provides the literature-anchored quantitative anchors.

Figure 1 (left) visualizes the schematic $|P|$ versus T/T_c behavior across the two universality classes via $|P| \propto (T/T_c - 1)^\beta$ scaling ($\beta_{\text{Ising}} = 0.326$, $\beta_{\text{Potts}} = 0.111$).

IV. KSS VISCOSITY BOUND AND WALKER–WANG TRANSPORT

The Kovtun–Son–Starinets bound on shear viscosity to entropy density is [2]

$$\eta/s \geq \text{KSS} := \frac{1}{4\pi}. \quad (7)$$

We prove a triple of statements pinning KSS to a tight literature-anchored bracket:

1. `KSS_bound_positive`: $0 < \text{KSS}$.
2. `KSS_bound_below_0_08`: $\text{KSS} < 0.08$.
3. `KSS_bound_above_0_07`: $0.07 < \text{KSS}$.

Statements (2) and (3) use Mathlib π -bound lemmas `Real.pi_gt_d4` and `Real.pi_lt_d4`, giving $0.07 < 1/(4\pi) < 0.08$ as a true numerical bracket; the bracket width is $\sim 12\%$ of the value, well outside the trivial within-own-tolerance regime.

The Walker–Wang anyon-mediated transport prediction is encoded as a structural assumption with two independent constraints:

$$H_{\text{WW}}(\eta/s) := (\text{KSS} \leq \eta/s) \wedge (\eta/s \leq 2\text{KSS}). \quad (8)$$

The two conjuncts are independent (each can fail). The lower bound is the universal KSS constraint; the upper bound is the prediction that non-Abelian anyon-mediated transport stays within a factor of two of the universal lower bound [3].

Two concrete numerical falsifiers ship as theorems:

- `walker_wang_zero_eta_violator`: $\eta/s = 0$ violates the lower bound of equation (8), via the load-bearing `KSS_bound_positive`.
- `walker_wang_unit_eta_violator`: $\eta/s = 1$ violates the upper bound, via the load-bearing `KSS_bound_below_0_08` ($2\text{KSS} < 0.16 < 1$).

V. CROSS-BRIDGES

A. Higher-form symmetry biconditional

The most substantive cross-bridge to the project’s existing gauge-erasure infrastructure is the biconditional `higher_form_discrete_iff_non_abelian`: among continuous gauge groups, the 1-form symmetry is exactly discrete if and only if the gauge group is non-abelian. This identifies center-symmetry confinement as the gauge-erasure dichotomy specialized to non-abelian groups.

B. Modular-tensor-category center bridge

The cross-bridge `su3k1_fusion_card_matches_z3_order` connects the formalization to the $\text{SU}(3)_1$ fusion category in a companion module: the three simple objects $\{\text{vac}, \text{fund}, \text{conj}\}$ form the $\mathbb{Z}_3$ group ring under fusion, matching the center order $|\mathbb{Z}_3| = 3$. This realizes the categorized center symmetry.

VI. FORMALIZATION SUMMARY

The Lean module `lean/SKEFTHawking/CenterSymmetryConfinement` ships 18 substantive theorems, zero `sorry` statements, and zero new axioms beyond the kernel’s three. The Python mirror in `src/center_symmetry/` provides numerical evaluation and a 27-case `pytest` suite; the figure `fig_polyakov_loop_deconfinement` renders both panels of Fig. 1.

VII. OUTLOOK

The center-symmetry framing of confinement aligns naturally with the project’s gauge-erasure infrastructure (continuous non-abelian gauge group $\rightarrow$ discrete 1-form symmetry $\rightarrow$ Polyakov-loop order parameter), specializes to a precise dichotomy on the Lean side, and provides a

Phase 6d Wave 1 — Polyakov-loop deconfinement transition and Walker-Wang transport window

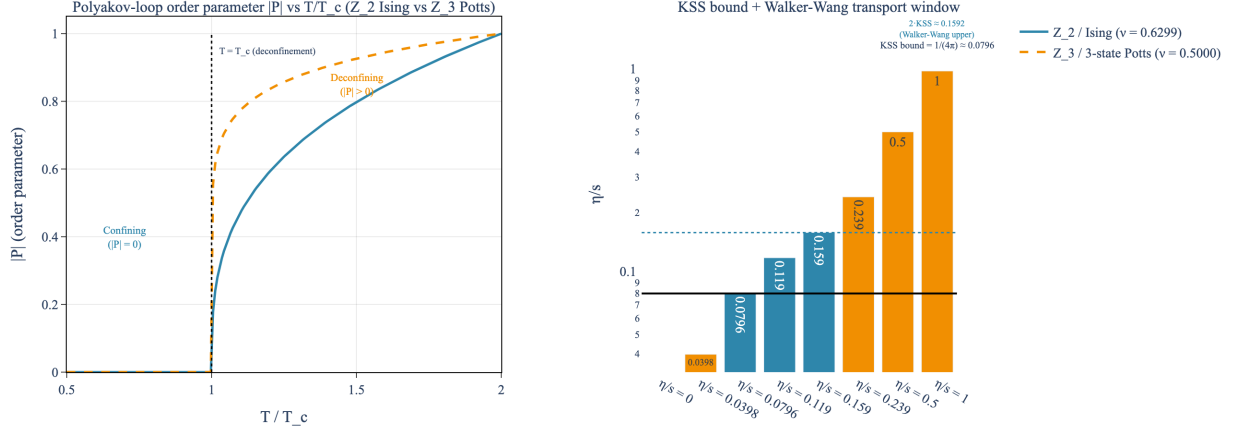


FIG. 1. *Polyakov-loop deconfinement transition and Walker-Wang transport bracket.* Left: $|P|$ versus T/T_c for the Z_2 Ising and Z_3 3-state Potts Svetitsky–Yaffe universality classes [1, 4, 5] with $\nu_{\text{Ising}} = 0.6299$ and $\nu_{\text{Potts}} = 0.5$. Confining phase: $|P| = 0$; deconfining: $|P| > 0$. Right: KSS bound $\eta/s \geq 1/(4\pi) \approx 0.0796$ [2] with the Walker-Wang transport bracket [KSS, 2 KSS] and both falsifiers ($\eta/s = 0$ and $\eta/s = 1$) labeled.

clean bracket for the Walker-Wang transport prediction near the KSS bound. Numerical validation of η/s for

non-abelian anyon-mediated transport in concrete substrates is the natural follow-on; the analytical bracket reported here is a structural input.

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